

David Bowie: The Chameleon of Rock

[B2]

Cantante, cantautore e attore, è stato una delle figure più importanti nella storia della musica. Ha creato personaggi iconici e influenzato profondamente la cultura pop durante tutta la sua carriera.



David Bowie is one of the most influential figures in the history of modern music, famous for his constantly-changing image and musical style. Known as the Chameleon of Rock, he [astonished](#) Britain in the 1970s, his most important decade, with his theatrical character Ziggy [Stardust](#), one of the most iconic creations in pop history, and the vehicle for some of his most famous songs.

MAKING MUSICAL HISTORY

Born David Robert Jones in Brixton, South London in 1947, David Bowie's career began in 1969, with the hit single Space [Oddity](#), about an astronaut, Major Tom, [marooned](#) in space. He followed this in 1970 with the album "[Hunky Dory](#)", whose track Life on Mars, when [released](#) as a single in 1973, would soon be recognised as a pop music classic. But it was the artist's next LP, "The Rise and Fall of Ziggy [Stardust](#) and the Spiders from Mars", introducing his androgynous, bisexual, glam, alien alter-ego to the world, that would launch Bowie to global fame. On 16 July 1972, Bowie, dressed in a multi-coloured [jumpsuit](#) and wearing make-up, performed the album's first single, Starman, on the popular TV music programme Top of the Pops. Singing the line, "I had to phone someone, so I picked on you ooh ooh", Bowie pointed straight down the camera lens, breaking the fourth wall. Britain's youth was [transfixed](#). Bowie-mania was born, and pop music would never be the same again.

I always had a repulsive sort of need to be something more than human. I felt very, very [PUNY](#) as a human. I thought, 'Fuck that. I want to be a superman'

FOUNDER OF GLAM ROCK

Bowie, with music combining hard rock and experimental pop, together with his extraordinary appearance, had founded a new genre, glam rock, along with his great friend, Marc Bolan, the lead singer of the band Tyrannosaurus Rex. Bowie took his look and sound on tour around Britain and then the world, creating the influential cult of Bowie. He produced another glam rock LP, "Aladdin Sane", only to then shock the music world by killing off Ziggy [Stardust](#) live on stage on 3 July 1973.

SOUL, FUNK AND DISCO

In 1975, Bowie was back, with a new image and musical style. The LP "Young Americans", with its global hit single Fame, mixed soul, funk and disco. The album elevated the musician to the US's rock aristocracy. One year later, Bowie introduced a new performance [persona](#) to the world with one of his most significant works, "Station to Station", including the hit single Golden Years. Now

performing as the [Thin](#) White Duke, the artist had added Krautrock (German-influenced rock) to his 1975 mixture.

BOWIE ON BOWIE

Bowie once said: “Rock ‘n’ Roll is the only material that I know is my vehicle for expression.” “I’m a writer,” he added, “I’ve written about the same subjects for over thirty-five, nearly forty years ... it’s all [despondency](#), [despair](#), fear, isolation.” His motivation, he said, was change: “I wanted to be a musician because it seemed rebellious, it seemed subversive. It felt like one could effect change.” He [actually](#) called himself “the first synthetic rock artist”, and felt that he was a [spearhead](#) of a new movement: “I feel that my contribution to rock and roll is all done. That was it, creating a whole era, by being the first to [take the plunge](#).” Bowie also had a modestly successful film career, starring in The Man Who Fell to Earth, Merry Christmas Mr. Lawrence, Labyrinth and Zoolander. In [fact](#), he famously said, “I am an [actor](#). My whole professional life is an [act](#).”

THE BERLIN YEARS

Non-stop recording and touring, and constant [character](#) changes, however, had destabilised Bowie’s own [personality](#). Trying to [kick a chronic cocaine addiction](#), he left America for West Berlin. While there, he produced three highly influential, experimental LPs, mixing European electronica and funk: “Low”, “Heroes” and “[Lodger](#)”. Now free from cocaine, the artist reached his peak of worldwide popularity in the 1980s, especially with a younger audience, as he reinvented himself as a more traditional pop artist with hits such as Ashes to Ashes (with one of the most innovative videos of all time,) Under Pressure (with Queen,) Let’s Dance, China Girl and Modern Love.

Music has given me over forty years of extraordinary experiences [...]
It’s been both my doorway of perception and the house that I live in.

A DEATH UNFORETOLD

David Bowie died on 10 January 2016 after a [liver](#) cancer diagnosis eighteen months earlier that only his closest collaborators and family knew about. It came shortly after releasing his final album “Blackstar”, the jazz-infused, critically-acclaimed album which had immediately entered the [charts](#) at number one around the world. Bowie’s musical genius had touched millions and his death was met with shock, sadness and [grief](#) from fans and [fellow](#) musicians [alike](#). Many critics consider that the first twenty years of Bowie’s career had produced the most original and creative sequence of albums in pop music history.

Glossary

- **Oddity** = stranezza
- **marooned** = abbandonato, bloccato
- **alike** = allo stesso modo
- **Stardust** = polvere di stelle
- **Hunky Dory** = tutto a posto
- **released** = pubblicare
- **jumpsuit** = tuta intera
- **transfixed** = rapita
- **persona** = personaggio
- **Thin** = magro, sottile
- **take the plunge** = buttarsi, fare il grande passo
- **astonished** = stupire, sorprendere
- **PUNY** = insignificante, debole
- **despair** = disperazione
- **act** = atto, messinscena
- **kick a chronic cocaine addiction** = superare una dipendenza
- **liver** = fegato
- **charts** = classifiche
- **grief** = dolore
- **despondency** = scoraggiamento
- **spearhead** = guida, uomo di punta
- **Lodger** = inquilino
- **fellow** = colleghi